

June 5, 2026

Javier Tapia, Principal
Portola Charter Middle School (LAUSD)
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(818) 654-3300

Dear Principal Tapia,

I am applying for the math teaching position at Portola Charter Middle School for the 2026-2027 school year. Teaching has been a throughline of my life going as far back as high school, and I am eager to culminate its integration into my professional career.

As a black belt karate instructor in high school, teaching students spanning ages from 6 to 60 gave me a keen appreciation for the distinction between the roles of knowledge transfer and mental/emotional development in education. This sensitivity served me in college when I tutored friends and taught formally as a TA, and during my 20 years as a software engineer often presented to colleagues on new technologies and workflows. These strands of education coalesced while living in Korea, where I worked at an edtech Hagwon as a project manager publishing multimedia ESL textbooks and founded a Toastmasters club, developing a novel education program for ESL speakers to overcome their hesitancy to speak. Finally, over the past 5 years I brought these disparate strands together into a coherent whole when I founded a karate dojo where I have been developing from the ground up an off-the-mat curriculum relating karate to such diverse disciplines as etymology, geometry, pedagogy, and chess. For example, I relate the circular and linear trajectory of kicks to Euclid's treatment of lines and circles as fundamental objects of geometry, and show that a kick angled 30 degrees above horizontal rises half a leg-length above belt height - without mentioning the words sine or hypotenuse.

I am excited for the opportunity to further discuss how I can adapt my experience and skills to meet the demands of the math classroom in order to best serve the needs of the students and the broader community.

Sincerely,

David Chung
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